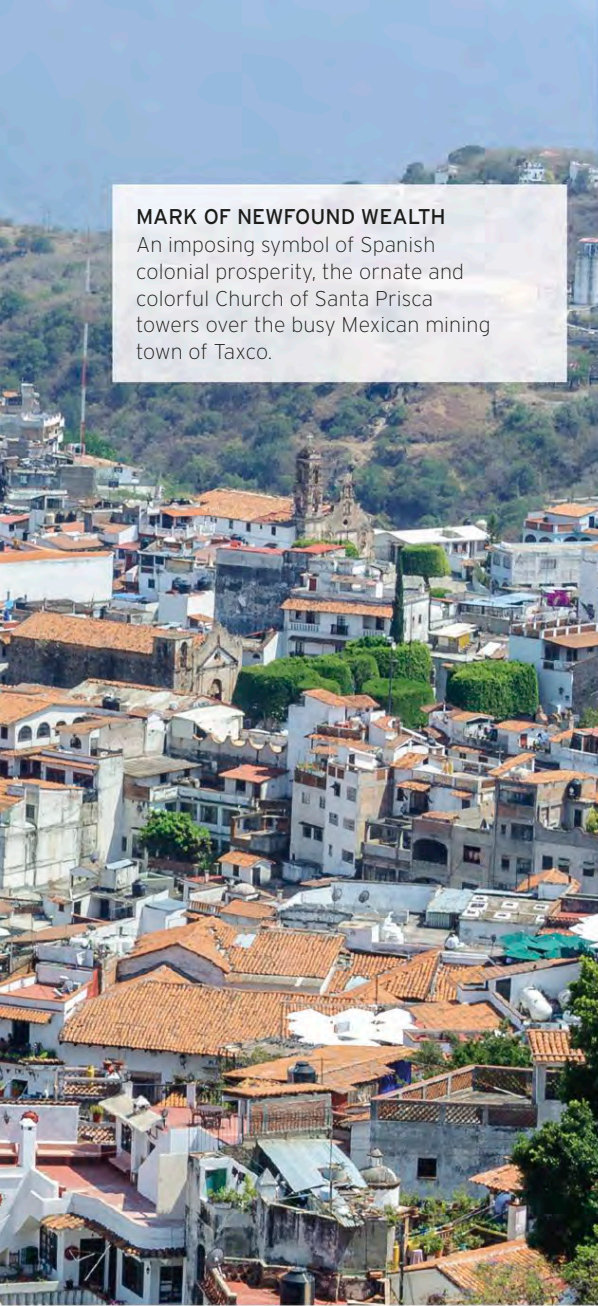


MARK OF NEWFOUND WEALTH

An imposing symbol of Spanish colonial prosperity, the ornate and colorful Church of Santa Prisca towers over the busy Mexican mining town of Taxco.



San Ignacio Miní

The red sandstone ruins of a Jesuit mission in the Argentine rainforest



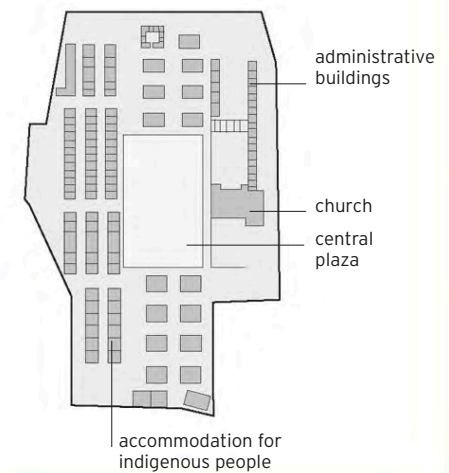
Built in the mid-17th century, San Ignacio Miní was one of many Jesuit missions, known as *reducciones*, established by Spanish colonizers to introduce—and often coerce—the native South American people to a Christian way of life. It was set up in the land of the Guaraní people, now the borderland of Argentina, Brazil, and Paraguay. It was built in the contemporary Spanish Baroque style but incorporating indigenous elements, which became known as the Guaraní baroque.

Fall from grace

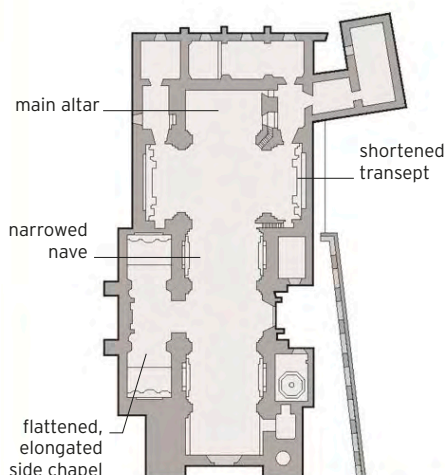
At the mission's peak, more than 2,000 people lived at the site, but the Jesuits eventually fell out of favor, and in the early 19th century, the mostly indigenous inhabitants attempted to destroy the buildings. Just the shell of the main mission building and the adjacent church survived, but San Ignacio Miní is nevertheless among the best preserved of the missions of the Guaraní region. The layout of the complex remains clear, and what is left of the walls and arches attests to the majesty of the architecture.

REDUCTIONS

In the parts of the Americas that came under Spanish rule in the 16th-18th centuries, many indigenous people were gathered into *reducciones* or "reductions," communities run by Jesuit missions. Following the plan of a typical Spanish village, there was often a central plaza bounded by a church, cemetery, monastery, and administrative buildings, as well as accommodation for the indigenous population.

**NARROW NAVE**

Taxco is situated on a hilly landscape and had little level ground suitable for large-scale construction. To fit the site in a small ravine, the design of the Church of Santa Prisca was modified by considerably narrowing the nave, which exaggerates the height of the towers flanking the main entrance.

**△ REMNANT OF COLONIALISM**

The ruins at San Ignacio are magnificent even in their current state. The mix of Spanish Baroque and Guaraní architecture is still evident in the disconnected walls and arches of the church.